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# Migrant Male Domestic Workers in Comparative Perspective: Four Case Studies from Italy, India, Ivory Coast, and Congo

Men and Masculinities

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**Maria Rita Bartolomei<sup>1</sup>**

## **Abstract**

This article is a contribution, from an anthropological perspective, to the understanding of how the current phase of globalization is transforming and shaping the meaning and the significance of paid domestic work, especially as far as the role of immigrant men as domestic workers is concerned. Drawing on literature about migration processes, gender relations, and domestic service, the article illustrates four case studies, set in Italy, Kerala, the Ivory Coast, and the Congo, respectively, from a comparative perspective. The research work adopted qualitative methodologies such as ethnographic interviews (355) and participant observation. The goal of the article is on one hand to show how, in all considered contexts, we witness a so-called racialization of paid domestic labor. On the other hand, the author's fieldwork aims at raising attention to the fact that male domestic workers do not think of themselves as "failed patriarchs." Migration processes, indeed, can affect gender relations and, consequently, the sexual division of labor in the domestic sphere in societies that both import and export labor.

## **Keywords**

gender and migration, male domestic workers, social reproduction

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<sup>1</sup> Sociology, University of Macerata, Italy

## **Corresponding Author:**

Maria Rita Bartolomei, Via Don Minzoni 2, 62100 Macerata, Italy

Email: [m.bartolomei@unimc.it](mailto:m.bartolomei@unimc.it)

## **Preliminary Remarks and Research Methods**

In the 1970s, many scholars and modernization theorists predicted the demise of paid domestic work in the modern era (Chaplin 1978; Coser 1973; Horn 1975; McBride 1976). Instead, however, in nearly all industrialized countries, nowadays we are witnessing a particularly striking presence of large numbers of migrant domestic workers from abroad (Datta et al. 2006; Gilpin et al. 2006; Wills 2007). In addition, even in the South of the world, where interstate migration is predominant, the number of people engaged in paid domestic service has grown rapidly (Moors 2003).

In recent years, increasing interest has been directed at incorporating gender analysis into theories of international migration (Hondagneu-Sotelo 1994, 1999; Kearney 1995; IMR 2006; Jolly and Reeves 2005; Sutton 1992). In this regard, we see increasing attention being paid to analyzing and theorizing in particular the so-called globalization of domestic work, mainly through the international markets and “global care chains” (Ehrenreich and Hochschild 2003; Hochschild 2000; Yeates 2004, 2007). Our understanding of domestic service, of its changes through history, and of its link to larger political and economical transformations, has been enriched by feminist and historical scholarship (Saptari 1999). The question of how the current phase of globalization is transforming and shaping the meaning and the significance of paid domestic work, especially as far as the role of immigrant men as domestic workers is concerned, has received little specific interest (Kilkey in this volume).<sup>1</sup> This is an interesting theoretical challenge if we consider that the “resurgence” of paid domestic work in certain countries, such as, for instance, Italy—but other European countries, too—has implied a certain “re-masculinisation” of the sector (Sarti 2006, 234; Scrinzi 2005).

This article is a contribution, from an anthropological perspective, to the understanding of how domestic service and contemporary migration are strongly interconnected. Drawing on the latest literature about migration, gender relations, and domestic service, the article focuses on local contexts to investigate the interactions between male domestic workers, their wives, and their employers.

My research aims to understand the dynamics of domestic service in a variety of settings and illustrates four case studies from a comparative perspective. Considering the tasks male domestic workers are performing, their relationships with employers and the main reasons that lead to them accepting that kind of job, we can identify four different patterns of domestic service. Patterns are framed through a number of key dimensions that, notably, identify each single case in question and guide discussion about the similarities and differences between case studies.

Although here I cannot properly further develop the important issue of “race”/ethnic/class/gender intersections, I will nonetheless try to bring them under consideration, sometimes using them as key axes of comparison.

The first case study is about a community of migrants coming from Kerala (a South-west Indian Union state) and living in Macerata, Italy. Special attention is devoted to

the conditions that favor the employment of these immigrants in the sector of domestic service. The research also examines the social relations between Keralite workers and their employers. In this case study, men more than women care for the elderly. According to them, they accept doing a socially disqualified, stigmatized, and subordinate job mostly because in Italy wage rates are almost ten times higher than Kerala. Consequently, I labeled it as the “caregivers-economic gap model.”

The second case study reports fieldwork carried out in Kerala on male immigrant domestic workers coming from the nearby state of Tamil Nadu (Indian Union). Pointing out the reasons why these people are leaving their country, the research draws attention to their hard working conditions and the physical and psychological abuses of which they are victims. The findings suggest that in this specific case, we can identify master–servant relationships rather than employer–worker relationships. It could, therefore, be defined as the “servants–social status gap model.”

The third case study is about male domestic workers who emigrate from the poor and dry African state of Burkina Faso to the wealthier and dynamic country of Ivory Coast. Although in theory in the Ivory Coast, there is a clear caring/cleaning/cooking distinction within domestic service, often in practice the same person can do a wide range of tasks. It is for this reason that I choose to label the case in point as the “handymen (cf. Kilkey in this volume)–cultural gap model.”

The last case study highlights the sexual division of paid reproductive labor in the Congo. Here, indeed, immigrant men who move from rural areas to densely populated urban zones largely refuse to carry out cleaning chores in the house but are proud to be good cooks. This fourth case study could be defined as the “cooks–ethnic gap model.” As I will try to show below, in fact, in this pattern, both the relationship and the distance between employer and domestic worker are shaped and reproduced mainly through “ethnicity.”

The research work has been carried out during different periods of time and it can be described as a “multisited ethnography” (Marcus 1995) approach. Consequently, it adopts a rich mixture of qualitative methodologies, among which I would especially point to participant observation and in-depth interviews. To explore interviewees’ thoughts, ideas, and experiences on the specific topic, I assembled a life history collection. During the data collection phase of the research process, I also observed the social actors recruited and talked to them. The interviewees are specifically encouraged, by questions and other verbal and nonverbal methods, to provide elaborate and detailed answers and to produce “thick description” of their views on the topic of the research. According to the “narrative of non-neutral interviewing” (Rapley 2004, 19), it is important for the interviewer to try and “communicate trust, reassurance and even likeableness” (Ackroyd and Hughes 1992, 108). We therefore always arranged interviews in “private” spaces without too much “outside interaction.” In Italy and the Ivory Coast, employers allowed me to witness their interactions with domestic workers during working hours. Their availability and help contributed to continuous and fruitful participant observation and to producing

better fieldwork data. Here, I can report neither the full richness of my data nor interviews in full, but a few more details are offered when introducing case studies.

## **Male Domestic Workers in Italy: A Case Study**

Italian women's participation in the labor market, the limited redistribution of domestic tasks between women and men (Sarti 2004, 19-26), and the shortfall in public services are fostering a strong and rising demand for low-cost labor in the domestic service sector (Andall 2000). Migrant workers are filling the gap and the recruitment of immigrant domestic workers is becoming a basic structural factor of the Italian immigration system (Ambrosini and Boccagni 2003) and an absolutely necessary resource for the functioning of our welfare (Sciortino 2004).

In this respect, I would like to draw attention to a community of migrants coming from Kerala<sup>2</sup> and living in the city of Macerata, in the Marche region of Italy. They form a small, closely related group of fervent Roman Catholics, composed of nine children, twenty-nine men, and nineteen women aged from twenty to fifty, all working in domestic service. Starting from the end of 2002, this community has become the subject matter of research fieldwork that explores the group's migratory chains and its members' insertion into their new context.<sup>3</sup>

Migration from Kerala is primarily a male phenomenon (Zachariah and Irudaya Rajan 2001, 49). In this community, however, we find quite a stable gender composition. Both women and men are all working in domestic service where they carry out a wide range of non-specialized tasks—domestic chores, shopping, cooking, laundry, and taking care of children and elderly people—at the same time. Most of them are live-in. Men more than women care for the elderly. Nevertheless, in this specific case, we have only a relative redetermination of male and female tasks. In Kerala—and mostly in the rural area where the sample comes from—gender roles' separation is quite clear: men work only outside the home while women devote themselves completely to domestic chores. But domestic service, as a profession, in Kerala is performed mostly by men: in upper class households, as well as in restaurants or hotels, domestic workers are always men—children or young immigrants, especially from Tamil Nadu. Poor Keralite women, orphaned, widowed, or without a husband, only occasionally go, generally in response to a specific request, to help other women (relatives, friends, acquaintances, or better-off neighbors) in exchange for a bowl of rice, a small gift, or some money for their children. In their native country, performing paid domestic work is considered a really degrading job for both married women and men.

In our culture domestic service is considered a really menial and degrading job! But I have to do that for me and my family (G.K., thirty years old, male).

None of us could accept to be a "servant" in Kerala! Here it is different. Performing this kind of job allows us to get a lot of money and if then the employers are kind . . . you are perfect! (S.R., thirty-seven years old, female).

Migrant Keralite women, who in Kerala have someone helping them with their household chores, in Italy work as domestic workers. The fact they are earning gives them more esteem and improves their economic situation but, in reality, their husband remains the absolute head of the family and these women cannot make their own decisions. I think it is important to note, too, that, while when they are in Kerala, husbands or brothers do not give any help with household duties, in Italy sometimes they do.

Selecting from a number of key dimensions those most suggestive of “tasks” and “reasons,” I chose to label this case study as the “caregivers–economic gap model.” In fact, nearly all the men who formed my sample (twenty-five of the twenty-nine) were working as carers for the elderly. This is a very interesting feature, if we consider that men are performing a kind of job that in Italy is typically feminine. Furthermore, if it is true that domestic service as a profession in Kerala is performed mostly by men, normally they do all the domestic chores but not caring. However, findings suggest that the reasons why middle-class men, literate and skilled, accept leaving their country to do a menial, stigmatized and subordinate job are almost exclusively economic or rather, the international wage differential. Changed attitudes obviously result also from cultural distance between workers and employers, but outcomes unequivocally suggest that economic reasons play a pivotal role. In this regard, it is interesting to note that, since all the workers’ sample hold a diploma and some of them have attended university, in some cases, workers are much more well-educated than their employers!

According to the twenty-nine men interviewed, to work in live-in domestic service is not a provisional solution to enable them to obtain a regular entry permit and then move to other economic sectors (Andall and Sarti 2004; Sarti 2006, 235). This job suits them because it provides board and lodging as well as solving employment problems. Moreover, the live-in formula reduces expenses and allows them to save up money for remittances. In comparison with Kerala, in Italy, wage rates are almost ten times higher. For this reason, even men who hold a diploma or have attended university accept doing a socially disqualified and subordinate job. As a matter of fact, they consider paid domestic work as an opportunity, as a means of deliverance from homeland poverty and backwardness.

In Kerala, even if you are educated, skilful and willing to work, it’s very difficult to find a job. If you find it, you earn very little, often less than your parents. This is a really very humiliating thing! Here, instead, whatever job you are performing you get a lot of money and so highly improve your and your family’s standard of living (G.Y., forty-eight years old, male).

Migrants send considerable remittances to Kerala monthly. Remittances are a vital income for the homeland family, trade, and economy. By saving, migrants increase their purchasing power, they invest a lot of money in land and real estate, and provide money for public infrastructure. The opportunity to sustain one’s family, to provide for one’s children’s education in the best schools, to take care of relatives, to

send expensive presents, and to spend money and invest therefore raises migrants to a higher standard of living in the homeland.

Thanks to my saving during my ten years in Italy I built a new, big house for my family in the more exclusive neighbourhoods of the city [Thrissur]; my two sons have attended university; I bought a newsstand for one brother and a marble factory for the other (T.N., forty-eight years old, male).

For all the above-mentioned reasons, the interviewees (with a few exceptions—six workers) stated that they are not very interested in changing their job. They declared that they are happy living-in with their employers, whom they often become attached to.

When the old man I was caring for died I had the opportunity to become a factory worker but I left my place [in the factory] to my sister's brother in law. Even if it is a full day's work, I prefer performing a caring job: it is not so heavy ... and if the employer is kind you can establish good relationships and manage your work schedule as you like (W.R., thirty-five years old, male).

The twenty employees interviewed belong to networks of relatives or families, which exchange information and take initiatives. No one applied to specialized agencies that supply labor. Instead, they made exclusive use of informal networks. Nevertheless, recruitment is always tied to a legal request for a certain person from the employer. In our sample, in fact, the forty-eight Keralites are all legal immigrants.

The households in which Keralite men do domestic service are from the middle, upper- or sometimes lower-middle classes. For the latter, often, to hire domestic workers is not a luxury or a status symbol but a need. In our country, in fact, the demand for paid domestic workers does not come only from the higher classes but more and more involves an increasing proportion of the population.

Employers state that they are very fond of their domestic workers, either because they show a willingness to establish good relationships, mostly with the elderly, or because they solve basic needs and problems. Elderly male employers say they prefer male carers because they are stronger and because they feel less embarrassed when bathing.

I have intentionally made the choice of hiring a man for care: he is stronger than a woman, I don't feel embarrassed or uneasy and, on the whole, I feel safer (M.S., eighty-seven years old, male employer).

The data reveal that migrants keep with them only children who are not of school age or who have already finished their education. This is for organizational reasons but also mostly because of fears of losing homeland contacts and culture. Children are given into the custody of their grandmothers or aunts and so will come back to Italy only after they finish school, unless their parents have in the meantime gone back to

Kerala. This is a difficult choice, bringing in its train unwanted and disappointing consequences, given the cost that separation from their parents has on children's psychological and emotional development. All the mothers interviewed confided to me that this decision is made by husbands because it is imposed upon them by relatives who have already emigrated. It is also the case that survey data collected directly in Kerala (November–December 2004) suggest that each decision to migrate is not an individual choice but a group decision always made by migrant men already settled in Italy. The migrant community, in fact, reproduces the typical structure of the patriarchal Indian family and hierarchical decision making is based on previous arrivals.

### **Kerala from Land of Emigrants to Land of Immigrants**

In the last quarter of the last century, migration to other states in India and abroad has been the single most dynamic factor in the otherwise miserable picture of development in Kerala. Migration, in fact, has contributed more than any other factor<sup>4</sup> to poverty alleviation and reduction in unemployment. However, even a country with very high rates of emigration can receive immigrants, for example, from the nearby state of Tamil Nadu.<sup>5</sup>

Tamil Nadu is a state in the south of India. It possesses the third largest economy among the Indian states and is the most industrialized and urbanized state in the Union. Nevertheless, there are a lot of people from there who cross borders in search of better lives.<sup>6</sup>

The study was carried out during the autumn of 2004 and is based on participant observation and 112 in-depth interviews.<sup>7</sup> The domestic workers' sample belongs to the largest group of immigrants from the rural area near the town of Mundanthurai in the Tirunelveli District. Poverty, unemployment, and poor wages are the reasons why these people leave their country. They live now in a shanty town in the suburbs of Trivandrum, the capital of Kerala. They live in crowded shacks, in bad sanitary conditions, and often without access to any medical care. Twenty five out of sixty-seven are illiterate; the others have only primary education. They are aged from fifteen to thirty-five; thirty of them are married, with wives and children living with them.

Unlike the first case, where laborers talking about living and working conditions did not report any current abuse and stated they had a regular contract in which all terms were respected, what immediately came to light during my fieldwork in Kerala were laborers' hard working conditions and the physical and psychological abuses they reported. Consequently, key dimensions such as "tasks" and "reasons" appeared to me less relevant than the "employer–worker relationship." I therefore thought of identifying this as a "servants–social status gap model." Outcomes indeed suggest that in this specific case, we can seek out master–servant relationships rather than employer–worker relationships.

Interviewees do not care for the elderly, but they do any kind of domestic chores, including heavier ones. Nobody is a live-in laborer, but they have a demanding work

schedule that does not allow them to play a regular, continuous, and integrated husband and/or father role. Both workers and employers are from a Hindu background and, according to the caste system,<sup>8</sup> the former belong to the lower section of *shudras*<sup>9</sup> and the latter to the upper castes. Despite social mobility and flexibility in modern India, castes often remain an indicator of social standing and occupation. My findings clearly show that, according to both workers and employers, the reference to “caste” (*varna/jati*) is directly or indirectly always present and that both the relationship and the distance between employer and domestic worker are mainly shaped and reproduced through the difference of status.

The interviewees work in private households doing all kind of domestic chores with a demanding work schedule but live elsewhere and have very little private life. Employers decide if and when the day’s work stops and fix the level of wages. No one reported sexual abuse, but thirty-five of them did report psychological or physical abuse.

I work a full day and I’m so busy that I can rarely take my rest. Sometimes I get home very late at night—10 pm or even midnight—and I’m very, very tired. I can’t see my children and spend time with my wife (P.J., twenty-eight years old).

My employers don’t give me any help, Madam is always screaming and shouting orders . . . (M.Y., seventeen years old).

Once I broke a bowl, Madam chased me all over the house to beat me and she did (T.J., nineteen years old).

The interviewees do not have regular contracts. Indeed, the characteristic feature of employment in Kerala is its informal nature (Prakash and Abraham 2004, 90). The structure of the urban labor market is still dominated by self and casual employment.

Even though most of the laborers state their willingness to go back to their home country after a few years, migration is a part of their life cycle aimed at achieving better living standards in the homeland. Married workers do not send remittances to their native country but support relatives and friends who are living with them. Single workers send monthly remittances to their parents or relatives in the homeland.

In the home country, domestic service is performed mostly by men but unpaid domestic work is done exclusively by women.

I don’t help my wife in doing domestic chores: that is a feminine task! What I’m doing at my employer’s house is another thing. This is a job, my job to support my family (R.J., thirty-one years old).

Even if servants perceive their economic, social, and personal situation as “*precarious and menial*” (S.J., thirty years), at the same time—through their narratives—they mask their suffering and express their personal fulfillment and success as “*providers for their spouses and families, for the household livelihood*” (T.K., thirty-five years old). Nevertheless, they state their willingness to stay in the

service sector until they find better job opportunities; they do not want their children to follow in their footsteps and become servants in turn.

My parents are old and ill: I also have to work to support my younger brothers and sisters . . . Anyway, I hope to find something better! (P.K., twenty years old).

It's difficult for a man to be at a woman's beck and call. But it is my "jāti"<sup>8</sup> and I do that to give my children a future better than mine! (J.L., thirty-three years old).

I don't like this job, but I want my children go to school and become civil servants . . . (G.Y., thirty-one years old).

Interviews conducted with men allowed me to observe the production of work identities and the representation of skills in a traditionally feminine sector. They think that a woman should not do male work, whereas a man can do feminine tasks.

I had no problem learning domestic chores and I think I'm a good servant. You know, a man if he wants to can learn and do everything. For women it is different. They often don't know even where to start in doing male tasks. They have no physical strength, resistance and endurance (T.Y., thirty-four years old).

In our culture a woman can't do male tasks. If she has a family (parents, brothers, sons or a husband), they don't allow her to do hard or difficult work. A man, instead, must do everything to accomplish his duty toward his family. We do feminine tasks but not at home . . . there, it is female work. Domestic service, instead, is mostly a male job. It's a paid job and we don't feel feminine at all! (H.K., thirty-five years old).

The employers belong to the middle and upper classes: politicians, top executives or Government officials, wealthy traders, and so on. Most of them are small manufacturers. Being young migrants, Tamilians represent such a cheap labor force that sometimes they can also be hired by middle-class families.

In the town domestic service is normally performed by migrant men. They are poor and needed . . . domestic service is their occupation, it's the proper occupation of their "jāti" (T.Y., forty years old, employer).

Domestic workers are hired by the household that pays them as well as telling them off and punishing them, but it is the lady of the house, who gives them orders and instructions. More than half of the female employers work outside the home as teachers or civil servants. For them, keeping domestic workers is essential to a well-run and well-kept household. Both female and male employers prefer male servants not only for fear of female servants' sexuality but also as an important sign of status.

We prefer male servants. They are stronger, less gossipy and more willing to learn (J.M., forty-five years old, employer).

I'm a high school teacher and my husband runs a small factory, we have got four children and I need help. Why do I prefer a man? We [upper caste] always have had lower Shudras<sup>9</sup> male servants (thirty-nine years old, female employer).

The evidence suggests that employers decide whether to have a male or female servant by judging the workers' skills and/or efficiency rather than their personal qualities. In any case, the men's feeling of superiority assumes that any task is performed better by a man. But, on the other hand, householders hardly consider a servant as a real man: he is regarded more as a thing than as a person. It is also for this reason that, even if there is a real possibility that a relationship could develop between a servant and a female employer, householders do not consider them as a threat or a source of shame for women at home (Chopra 2006).

### **"Boy Cuisiniers" in Abidjan<sup>10</sup>**

The Ivory Coast is a country in Western sub-Saharan Africa, which overlooks the Guinean gulf.<sup>11</sup> Since 1983, the official capital has been Yamoussoukro, but Abidjan is the largest city and serves as the *de facto* capital. It is also the city with the largest population in French-speaking Western Africa. Through its production of coffee and cocoa, the Ivory Coast was an economic powerhouse until the economic crisis in the 1980s.<sup>12</sup> A constant factor in the entire history of the country is the presence of male domestic workers from abroad. Most are from Burkina Faso and some from Ghana, Mali, or Benin. Women have entered this occupation only as nannies.

This study is based on participant observation and 125 in-depth interviews with people living and working in Abidjan.<sup>13</sup> Here, I will report data collected during the anthropological fieldwork carried out during March–April 1997, but previous information and experiences are used as well.<sup>14</sup> The workers interviewed were aged from twenty-five to fifty, sixty of them were married, with a wife and children living with them in Abidjan's poor suburbs. I chose them because they had been working as a domestic for several years. They come from the northern rural zones of Burkina Faso,<sup>15</sup> where hot desert winds accentuate the dryness of the region. In recent years, Burkina Faso has been subject to greater competition and falling prices in the global market for its agricultural crops. Interviewees were shepherds or small farmers in their homeland, who had been forced to leave their country looking for better economic opportunities. They turned to migration after being recruited by Ivorian plantation companies. This came to an end because they were dismissed during the crisis or resigned because of the excessively hard work. Most of them had precarious or seasonal jobs that were sometimes very hard. They heard from friends or fellow Ivorians about the possibility of finding jobs as servants and so they began seeking employment as "petit boys." In that way they started to work as houseboys and then, in many cases acquiring knowledge and experiences, were promoted to cooks.

Most of the domestic workers are illiterate but all are French speaking. Thus, when interviewing them, I did not need a translator. Of the eighty sample domestic workers interviewed, forty were houseboys, twenty were cooks, and twenty were cooks who also cleaned the house. Only one cook had formal cooking school experience. Others learned in their employers' homes. In the Ivory Coast, boys are rarely live-in domestic workers, although sometimes nannies are. All of the men in the sample were full-time workers six days a week. They wore a uniform: kitchen suit, houseboy suit, and so on, of which they were proud.

In the Ivory Coast, there is a clear caring/cleaning/cooking distinction: the cleaning male domestic worker is usually called "petit boy" or simply "boy" even if he is not young at all,<sup>16</sup> the cook is called "boy cuisinier," and the nanny is called "nounou." In upper class villas, we find an entire domestic staff consisting of a cook (who is also the head of the staff); one or two houseboys doing the cleaning, washing, laundry, ironing, waiting, and other domestic chores; a gardener; a doorkeeper; and a nanny if needed.

In spite of this formal caring/cleaning/cooking distinction within the Ivorian labor market of domestic service, outcomes show that often in practice the same person can do a wide range of tasks. Differing qualifications depend on abilities and skills acquired by the domestic workers in a sort of career, but these qualifications are always used to determine wage rates, rarely to clearly differentiate the actual task the workers do. If in upper-class households we can see a complete domestic staff, generally middle-class households hire a boy who can do domestic chores and at the same time act as gardener, carer for children, driver, or attendant.

Since key dimensions of both "tasks" and "cultural distance" between workers and employers have emerged as major issues here, I chose to label the case in point as the "handymen-cultural gap model."<sup>17</sup>

The employer-worker relationships, in fact, take place in a postcolonial context where social, economic, and power differences and discrimination are mostly explained, accepted, and justified by assuming a lack of ("modern") knowledge and culture on the part of the poorest African people. This is quite evident in Western and other non-African ways of thinking and speaking. But it is a somewhat mainstream discourse also used since Independence by Ivorian elites to justify the concentration of wealth and power in their hands (Bartolomei 2001, 121-37). In this regard, I would like to point out that in the workers' stories it emerges that they regret not having enough education to perform a non-menial job. They think their lack of schooling keeps them dependent and causes a restriction of choice. In this case study more than others, all workers state their willingness to accept being in their employers' service all day only to give their children the opportunity to go to school, improve their status, and become "white-collar" workers.

Domestic workers generally believe that Lebanese employers are rude, abusive, and exploitative.<sup>18</sup> But the laborers interviewed work to support their families in Abidjan and sometimes their parents and relatives in their homeland. So, to avoid unemployment, they accept working even for a Lebanese family.

I hear my friends speaking about their beautiful uniform, their afternoon rest, their holiday, their employers' presents and gifts, and so on. Nothing like that for me! I don't tell them out of pride. But they [Lebanese employers] really treat me like a slave. But I have six children and old parents to support, a house to build and many debts to pay off . . . (S.S., thirty-six years old, boy).

Sometimes, indeed, they consider domestic service a job like any other or even better than others—a job surely less heavy than others in the plantations, forest or wood yard, and so on (Deniel 1991).

I like my job, I really like it. Before I worked either in a plantation or a wood yard. You can't imagine how hard it can be. Besides, you are always dusty and poorly dressed (I.T., thirty-one years old, boy cuisinier).

Most Ivorian employers are on the payroll of the Government or big plantation owners. They did not want to speak a lot about their private life. In any case, they feel as if they are very good people in giving the poor an opportunity to work and learn for the future.

We pay the current wage in the sector and we are sympathetic and tolerant with our "servants." As nowadays women work outside the home, for the good running of their households, they need help (D.O., forty-three years old, employer).<sup>19</sup>

They are not afraid of the risk that day-to-day-interaction with *Madame* could create feelings or a strong "dangerous" relationship: they consider servants as "little men" who are absolutely not comparable to themselves.

If ever that were to be the case, it would be worse for them [wife and servant]. They both maybe risk being beaten and surely being thrown out of the home (R.D., fifty-two years old, employer).

European or American employers were much more forthcoming. In their case, I spoke directly with female employers. Most of them were housewives who did not need domestic staff. Their husbands had very different jobs: embassy employees, agents for oil companies, shipowners or for other firms, manufacturers, wood traders, sawmill managers, and so on. Expatriate skilled workers from abroad in the Ivory Coast earn higher wages so their standard of living is rising. Consequently, white women, even if they were not used to having domestic workers in their homeland and sometimes feel that leaving their own home in the hands of another person is like a loss of control over the household, hire a boy. In fact, for white people to have domestic workers in Africa is something taken for granted, a *sine qua non*. Cheap manpower allows women to rent bigger houses, to give dinners and parties, to go to the gym and the beach, to make the acquaintance of ambassadors and high officials, wealthy traders, and magnates. In this way, they fill the frustrating gap caused by losing parents, friends, and the places and habits of their homeland with the feeling of being a really "rich lady."

Apart from this, most female employers confided to me that to have a man inside the house all day can be embarrassing. At first it was difficult, then they got used to their constant presence. In some cases, day-to-day interaction brought about a strong relationship between Madam and boy so that they “plotted and conspired” against the *patron*. This raised their husband’s suspicion.

Normally, it is the male employer who pays domestic workers, but it is the lady of the house—either a housewife or an outside worker—who gives them orders and instructions. According to the interviewees, to work at *Madame*’s service is really difficult for them when in their own family they are still the unquestioned head of the household; it is harder in the case of African employers, from whom they are not culturally distant at all.

Burkinabe declared that in their community, gender roles are clear and distinct: women have their own realm of power but traditionally men give orders to men and women to women. For this reason, all the workers in the sample agreed in saying that,

to obey a black woman can be really degrading for a black man (K.W., fifty-one years old, “boy cuisinier”).

We, the “boys”, prefer to work for white people. They, for example, urge you to go to evening courses and give leave for that. Sure, the “whites” can be bad, too, but that’s rare (T.W., fifty years old, “boy cuisinier”).

On my mother’s side I come from royal stock: in the past my family had many slaves and servants. You can understand how humiliating it can be for me nowadays to be a servant for people belonging to other less important lineages. For this reason I prefer to work for foreign people who know neither my past nor my family (G.K., forty-six years old, boy).

As these short interview extracts clearly show, workers said they prefer to work for Western people for a wide range of reasons. First of all, in this case, the cultural distance is so big that it cancels any possibility of comparison between male worker and female employer. According to them, in fact, the problem is not so much in doing a feminine task—for poor people paid domestic work is deemed a job like any other or even better than others—but in the relation of power, especially that between male servant and female employer. Furthermore, according to the interviewees, Western people usually are more willing to pay legal wages and social insurance and they often turn out to be more available, helpful, willing, sympathetic, and understanding; and less strict and abusive. Domestics’ greatest aspiration, in fact, is to be treated not like invisible working hands, but as people with their own lives, experiences, wishes, feelings, ideas, and human dignity. Other feelings shared by domestic workers are a sense of precariousness, uncertainty, inadequacy, and so on. This is surely because they have not any legal protection, they have low wages and cheap competitors, and their employer can dismiss them at any moment. Moreover, being immigrants, corrupt police and the military unlawfully confiscate their articles. But I think their feelings also come from doing a job that somehow contributes to a kind of “de-genderization” of them as men.

## Paid Reproductive Labor in the Congo

Even if domestic servants have historically been male in Africa (Tranberg Hansen 1989, 1992), in the Congo,<sup>20</sup> there is a clear gender distinction between cooking and cleaning the house: domestic cooks are men while house cleaners are women. Congolese men, in fact, refuse to clean the house.

Here, I will report data collected during anthropological fieldwork carried out during December 2006 and January 2007. The study is based on participant observation and fifty in-depth open-ended interviews with people living and working in Point Noire.<sup>21</sup> The workers interviewed were aged from twenty-five to fifty; the men were married, with their wives and children living with them in the poor suburbs of the town. They migrated from nearby rural areas to escape the poor conditions in peasant agriculture and the lack of rural employment alternatives. They were illiterate and moved to the city attracted by the mirage of easy profits and better living conditions for themselves and their families. Most of them had reached domestic service after doing different heavy and precarious jobs: in the forest or wood yards, mines, or oil and gas fields. Male cooks have no formal training, since there is no school, but learn in restaurants and families' homes. Even though they are doing a job that contrasts with common gender expectations and often implies moving between many employers' households, male cooks still consider themselves lucky to have a job that allows them to support their family.

This last case study could be defined as the "cooks-ethnic gap model".<sup>22</sup> Here, in fact, we have Congolese men who, by creating and maintaining the distinction between cooking/cleaning, seek to reduce the humiliation of being in women's service. In fact, by refusing to do the cleaning and other domestic chores, male cooks construct their work in a manner that seeks to preserve gender identity.

In the Congolese culture men are defined in terms not of being but doing. For this reason I don't want to do the cleaning. This is a feminine task. Cooking for the upper classes and white people is another thing. It requires a long apprenticeship and a set of skills like patience, willingness to learn, cleverness, understanding and inventiveness, reputation and reliability (Y.M., fifty years old).

Cooks agreed in saying they preferred to work for single men because women are much more demanding. Furthermore, to be fundamentally at a woman's service is really degrading for a man. They can improve their skills by learning more difficult dishes and cookery and so creating a kind of career. Nevertheless, because of the job's nature and conditions, as well as because of the power and authority that are inherent in the relationship between employer and employee, most of them think they are "... *performing a kind of job without any future. I hope one day I will move to better positions...*" (K.W., thirty-five years old).

Female workers were widows or single mothers; they work to support their children. They were very collaborative with me, seeing participation in my study as an opportunity, that is, a way to avoid their stories from remaining untold. According

to them, gender relations are preserved within the Congolese family as well as in their workplace.

Men don't give any help either in the workplace or at home. Even if they are cooks, they refuse to cook for their own family and refuse to do anything unpaid. They think that a man's job is only a job for a wage (A.T., thirty-five years old, female cleaner).

They accept cooking any kind of dishes for their employers other than very typical local dishes. In the case of cleaning they often refuse to do it, saying: "I can't do that! It requires feminine tasks and skills. It isn't a man's job!" (V.D., fifty years old, female cleaner).

My findings suggest that entering the field of domestic work is easier than others because of workers' and employers' social networks. Effectively, women have access to fewer alternative opportunities such as, for instance, the retail trade or being a day laborer in agriculture. Compared with other kinds of jobs, therefore, all in all domestic service is lighter and better paid work. Furthermore, women consider domestic service as an opportunity to enter into the upper class world, which often is also the Western world.

I prefer to do the cleaning rather than work in the fields. That is dusty and heavy work. Living with rich and well educated people I learned a lot of things and I had also the chance to go to evening courses. Now I'm much better and I hope to meet and marry a rich man (S.K., twenty-six years old, female cleaner).

All employers belong to the upper class; they are professionals, government officials, agents for oil and gas companies or other firms, manufacturers, wood traders, or mine managers. Almost all men declared that they do not carry out any domestic tasks at all, whereas women are tempted to overestimate the true participation of their spouses in the domestic sphere. Employers tend to create distance between themselves and their employees mostly by class but also by ethnicity.

All the cooks who are working in Point Noire came from the forest or the poor hinterland villages. They are completely different from us [African town dwellers]: they belong to completely different lineages and [ethnic] groups, without any power or prestige. They have no literacy and still retain their foreign beliefs, traditions, customs and habits (R.S., forty-five years old, African wood trader).

This interview extract can well explain the second key dimension I pointed out in this "model," that is, the "ethnic gap." As a matter of fact, outcomes show that, in this pattern, both the relationship and the distance between employer and domestic worker are shaped and reproduced mainly through "ethnicity." Congolese employers keep a distance from their cooks by specifying that the latter belong to completely different ethnic groups, backward and historically powerless and subordinate.

As I said before, male cooks are proud of their masculinity and try to keep it by creating and maintaining the distinction between cooking and cleaning as a way to distance themselves from tasks they consider absolutely “feminine.” The evidence suggests that such a clear sexual division in paid domestic work brings about two important consequences. On one hand, we see greater chances for black women to enter the labor market of domestic service. On the other hand, because of the racialized construction of black male sexuality, male cooks are perceived as a sexual threat in the house. As a result, male employers tend to regulate interactions between male cooks and their wives or other women of the household. Indeed, they seek to render cooks “invisible men” (Chopra 2006) and try to “domesticate masculinity” by creating unequivocal relations of hierarchy, respect, and distance through sets of practices that include clothing (cooks always wear a strict uniform), speech (cooks always address their employers as “patron” or “madame”), gestural code (eyes lowered, “listening” posture, etc.), spatial locations (they are not allowed to enter bedrooms and bathrooms), and so on.

The cook runs the kitchen, this is his realm. He dresses in a strict uniform and he is not allowed to move round the house. I have a wife and five daughters and I don't like the fact that they have a man around all the time (S.K., fifty years old, African mine manager).

They [the cooks] are so strong, rough and wild that is better to settle them (T.H., thirty-nine years old, African manufacturer).

Finally Congolese workers often idealize, and seek to attain, domesticity and gender values of hegemonic masculinities.

I hope my sons will become oil company agents like my “patron,” marry a wife who runs the house as “madames” do and have a good cook like me (G.J., thirty-one years).

## **Concluding Remarks**

My research aims to understand the dynamics of domestic service in a variety of settings. Considering a number of key dimensions such as the tasks male domestic workers are performing, their relationships with employers and the main reasons why they decide to leave their homeland to do a menial, stigmatized, and subordinate job, I have identified and synthetically presented four different patterns of domestic service. Despite differences and peculiarities, in all the above-mentioned case studies, we can identify strategies for constructing manageable masculinities that are mainly centered on asserting a breadwinner identity. This involves supporting their own families through the promotion of the single male wage earner. As a core theme, male domestic workers present themselves first of all as responsible husbands and fathers in charge of maintaining their family and of assuring a positive developmental impact on their children. Furthermore, they consider domestic service an even better job than other heavy and precarious employment. Male servants

generally do not think of themselves as failed patriarchs: they have reconfigured the patriarchy through a revaluation of the terms of work status and reaffirm masculinity as working outside the home. In this way, distinguishing between paid and unpaid domestic work, they are able to consolidate their position as heads of households and try to preserve a hegemonic patriarchal system. In fact, as we have seen, male domestic workers do not necessarily carry their skills into their own domestic arrangements nor do they help their wives in domestic chores. Thus, the gender divisions of roles are generally unchallenged by the work of men as domestics and we witness the persistence of the so-called separate sphere ideology.

Nevertheless, examining in depth the collected narratives, the picture seems more complicated than that. Since the source of men's identity and legitimacy lies outside the domestic sphere, doing "feminine," menial, and dependent tasks within the domestic sphere is partially perceived by domestic workers as a loss of manhood. My research shows that they feel that their real traditional masculinity is questioned. As we have seen especially in the third and fourth cases, for the African male domestic workers, the problem is not so much in doing feminine tasks but in being in a woman's service. In the past, in fact, male servants had male masters, while today the interviewees generally have a female employer; they therefore feel uneasy, particularly older married ones. Moreover, the concept of domestic work (even paid domestic work) as a typically feminine task is spreading in Asia and Africa, possibly because of the influence of Western culture. As we have seen in looking at Burkinabe workers, the perception of a progressive loss of masculinity is often linked to people feeling as if they are suspended in a condition without a definite status. In this sense, we can agree with scholars who talk of either masculinities in transition (Hooper 2000), or masculinities in crisis (Clare 2000) or about a kind of "failure of patriarchy" (Quayum and Ray in this issue).

In this regard, I think it is important to note that my outcomes unequivocally show that the contexts where we witness masculinities in transition or in crisis are also the foremost settings where phenomena of construction and negotiations of both hegemonic and subordinate masculinities occur. In fact, as I go on to show below, one of the major strategies employed by the former to create, and keep under, the latter is their increasing "de-genderization." Hegemonic masculinities, indeed, make use of their social, economic, and cultural power—enforced also thanks to race/ethnic/class intersections—to deny and bring down the real and symbolic manliness of the other (subordinate) men.

There is another important issue I would like to point out. Domestic work is reproductive work. Reproductive work is not confined to the maintenance of physical bodies, it is concerned with the social and cultural reproduction of human beings, too (Glenn 1992). At the same time, reproductive labor consists of a set of tasks that are necessary to reproduce one's lifestyle and affirm the status of the household. Thus, the actual doing of the work—who does it, when, and where—is a crucial part of its meaning. It is also for this reason that the employer must differentiate between herself or himself and the person who does the dirty work. My

article shows that not only gendered but also class and ethnic identities are a means of doing so. Workers participating in my study, indeed, are all somehow migrants: transnational migrants in the first case, interstate migrants in the second (Indian Union) and the third (Africa), and intrastate migrants (from rural to urban zones) in the last. Being migrants, the domestic workers' personhood is turned into otherness. As different meanings are assigned to different jobs, through household labor (dirty, menial, degrading, dependent, and cheap) the identities of employers and workers—us and them—are confirmed (Anderson 2001). Consequently, the proliferation of migrants in this sector can be explained by their availability and cheapness, by welfare's inefficiency, but also by "ethnicity." The employment of a migrant domestic worker, in fact, enables the expression and reproduction of the proper role of privileged groups and their proper relations to wealthy households as doers of jobs that citizens are too important to do (Anderson 2001). Generally, these workers are in the weakest position in the labor market (just think about undocumented migrants in Italy). They do not have the power to refuse the kind of job that anyone with a choice would do. We can therefore agree that within domestic work, in certain cases "migrant status is more influential than gender in determining one's chances and handicaps in the labour market" (Sarti 2006, 235). For immigrant people, in fact, domestic sector employment often represents a survival strategy in both the global North and the global South.

Although there are qualitative differences in the four different contexts, everywhere social interactions between workers and employers reproduce distance and difference (Tranberg Hansen 1989). Notwithstanding that workers and employers share an interactive social space, influence each other, and sometimes become fond of one another, they are and remain "distant companions" (Tranberg Hansen 1989). Workers have to learn rules of exclusion, permission, and prohibition and this hybrid identity, constructed simultaneously as stranger and family member of the household (Chopra 2006, 157), contributes to humiliating and degrading workers, and challenges their subjective experience of masculinity.

The evidence suggests that, according to theories about hegemonic masculinities (Connell 1995; Connell and Messerschmidt 2005), the use of paid domestic labor performed by some men allows others (employers) to avoid participating in domestic chores and so to reassert a gendered authority position. In wealthier countries and/or classes (female and sometimes male), paid domestic labor is used to support middle- and upper-class women's entry into paid work. Everywhere, in fact, native men generally continue to dislike housework and care functions. Often, the upper classes can improve the quality of their parenting at the cost of immigrant people, who are often forced to leave their children in their homeland (see the case of the Keralites), or are not allowed to play regular, continuous, and integrated father and/or mother roles (see the case of Tamilians). Home-state men therefore seem to play an important role in the international division of social reproductive labor. In this sense, we can posit that male domestic labor is deeply embedded in the performance, construction, and negotiations of both hegemonic and subordinate

masculinities. Since in all the contexts considered, we see the so-called racialization” of paid domestic labor (Anderson 2000), the “ethnicity” issue appears to be central in the production of migrants’ subordinate masculinities (Connell 1995; Glenn 1992). The continuity and reaffirmation of hegemonic masculinities, in fact, is still rooted in the subordination and exploitation of both women and other groups of men who have few cultural or economic resources: nowadays migrant men. The dynamics of these new hegemonic masculinities show internal contradictions: subordinate masculinities influence dominant ones and, in creating contradictory and competing frames of masculinity, consolidate the idea of multiple masculinities (Connell and Messerschmidt 2005). If it is true that patriarchal hierarchies and ideologies still operate on multiple levels within both employing and serving households, both male workers and employers are challenged by the emancipation of women in recent times and try to develop strategies to manage complex processes of negotiation and empowerment of masculine identities. Unfortunately, greater gender equality, if it is the case, is obtained at the cost of continuing the gap between cultures, social classes, and countries. Women therefore contribute to creating and recreating hegemonic and subaltern masculinities, too.

To sum up, the article seeks, on one hand, to focus on how migrations can shape gendered institutions and construct gender differentially in women’s and men’s access to, and control of, resources, values, identities, choices, roles, behaviors, and power relations. It also seeks to consider how they affect the societies and cultures in which women and men live. The themes also address the dialectics of globalization as a result of conflicting interaction between global and local political economies and sociocultural conditions, yielding mixed outcomes for women and men. On the other hand, my work aims to raise attention to the variety of forms that domestic service is assuming in this global era. Domestic service, in fact, is becoming a complex occupation, often difficult to conceptualize unequivocally. In so doing, the article compels a rethinking of work and labor, and emphasizes the need to develop dynamic fields of research to further understand the relationships between globalization, migration, and social reproduction (Kearney 1995; Kilkley in this volume; Yeates 2007).

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### **Notes**

1. Studies on male domestic workers are, for example, Ray (2000) and Tranberg Hansen (1989).

2. Kerala is an Indian Union State with an area of almost 39,000 sq km and a population of 30 million inhabitants. The capital is Trivandrum; languages spoken are Malayalam and English, together with many local tongues. Most of the Keralite people are Hindus, many are Muslims and Christians.
3. The research is based on 320 in-depth interviews: 48 migrants; 66 people from the importing society; and 206 people from the exporting society. Here, I report only the findings from sixty-eight interviews: forty-eight domestic workers and twenty Italian employers. The interviews with the Keralites were in English. For more information, see Bartolomei 2005; 2006; 2007; 2008.
4. Kerala has the highest rates of rural and urban unemployment among young and educated people of all Indian states. In the development literature, it is known as the so-called, much-debated Kerala model: a high HDI with low per capita income and high incidence of poverty.
5. Tamil Nadu has an area of 130,000 sq km, divided into 26 districts. Most of the Tamil people are Hindus, many are Muslims and Christians ([www.tn.gov.in](http://www.tn.gov.in); [www.census.tn.nic.in](http://www.census.tn.nic.in)).
6. There are an estimated 77 million Tamils scattered around the world ([www.tn.gov.in](http://www.tn.gov.in); [www.babylon.com.definition/Tamil\\_people/English](http://www.babylon.com.definition/Tamil_people/English)).
7. Sixty-seven to Tamilian men working in domestic service and forty-five to their Keralite employers. Participants in the study were recruited through personal contacts using the snowball sampling method. Tamilians had poor English-language proficiency, so I needed a local translator who also helped me as cultural mediator.
8. The pattern of social classes in Hinduism is called the "caste system." It mixes up two different schemes: the *Varna* (basic caste) and the *Jāti* (subcaste). *Jāti* is a traditional hereditary system of social structuring dividing society into several thousand communities. Each *Jāti* typically has an association with job function (occupation) and religious beliefs. [www.friesan.com/caste.htm](http://www.friesan.com/caste.htm). Findings suggest that, although associations of occupation with caste have also been changing, nowadays the reference to *jāti* as indicator of social stratification is still not so unusual. In fact, although the Indian Constitution has outlawed caste-based discrimination and despite efforts by social reformers to oppose the caste system and the practice of "untouchability," the system's values are still held strongly today and influence the social life (Bayly 1999).
9. *Shudra* is the lowest *Varna* in the traditional Hindu caste system (Callahan and Pavich 1998).
10. Compare Deniel (1991).
11. The Ivory Coast has an area of 322,462 sq km, the population is 18 million: Muslim (55 percent), Christian (35 percent), and Animist (10 percent). The official language is French. It was a French colony until it became independent in 1960. [www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2846.htm](http://www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2846.htm); [www.tlfg.ulaval.ca/axl/afrique/cotiv.htm](http://www.tlfg.ulaval.ca/axl/afrique/cotiv.htm).
12. The country's problems have been exacerbated by two "coups d'état" (1999 and 2001) and a civil war since 2002. The crisis ended after a political agreement was signed by the President L. Gbagbo and the rebel leader G. Soro in 2007. [www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2846.htm](http://www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2846.htm); [www.tlfg.ulaval.ca/axl/afrique/cotiv.htm](http://www.tlfg.ulaval.ca/axl/afrique/cotiv.htm).

13. Eighty to black male domestic workers and forty-five to their employers either European (twenty), or Ivorian (sixteen), or Lebanese (nine). Participants in this study were also recruited through personal contacts using the snowball sampling method.
14. I have not been to the Ivory Coast since 1997 and I am not sure whether the situation has changed in the meantime. Friends and acquaintances still living there say that the long civil struggle has worsened the economic and social situation. Almost all foreigners have left the country and so the opportunity to be employed in domestic service has strongly diminished. It still remains a male occupation.
15. Burkina Faso is a landlocked country, with an area of 274,200 sq km located in the middle of West Africa and bordering on the Ivory Coast in the southwest. Geographically it is in the Sahel with savannah, brush plains, and scattered hills. The population is 14.4 million: Muslims (45 percent), Christians (20 percent), and Animists (35 percent). [www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2834.htm](http://www.state.gov/r/pa/ei/bgn/2834.htm).
16. "Boy" is the term used to refer to a grown man who is African and a servant (Brandford 1978).
17. Here the word "culture" is used in both its classical meaning, referring to knowledge and education, and wider anthropological non-evolutionary meaning, which includes any aspect of individual and social life.
18. The Lebanese community in the Ivory Coast has been growing since 1975 and has invested heavily in urban real estate as well as in hotels and restaurants inland. Through their monopolistic practices and custom frauds, Lebanese dominate Ivorian commerce and trade. [www.countrystudies.us/ivory-coast/72.htm](http://www.countrystudies.us/ivory-coast/72.htm).
19. Nobody talked of social insurance and other legal issues.
20. The Republic of the Congo is also called Congo-Brazzaville to distinguish it from the nearby Democratic Republic of Congo. The country has an area of 342,000 sq km and a population of 3.6 million. Religions: traditional believers 50 percent, Roman Catholic 33 percent, other Christian 15 percent, and Muslim 2 percent. The main natural resources are petroleum, wood, zinc, uranium, natural gas, and diamonds. The official language is French. It was a French colony until it became independent in 1960. Before the 1997–2003 war, about 9,000 Europeans and non-Africans lived in the Congo. Only a fraction of this number remains. They live in the capital Brazzaville or in Point Noire, on the coast. [www.congo-siteportail.info](http://www.congo-siteportail.info).
21. Eighteen male cooks, ten female domestic workers, and twenty-two employers. They were all French speaking so I did not need a translator.
22. Without going into debates about its meaning, the term ethnic/ethnicity is used to indicate "a group of people who perceive themselves and are perceived by others as sharing cultural traits such as language, religion, family customs and food preferences" (Ore 2006, 9).

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